

United States — Student Visa & Study Abroad Guide

Updated: September 2026

Important: This is general educational information, not legal, immigration or financial advice. Visa rules, fees, financial thresholds, processing times and document requirements can change. Always verify the current official authority and institution requirements before applying.

Official immigration resources

Visa guidance: <https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/student-visa.html>

Immigration / study information: <https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/>

At a glance

Visa / route	F-1 student visa
Common intakes	Fall is the main intake; Spring and selected Summer starts depend on the institution.

Typical student visa pathway

1. Select a SEVP-certified institution and programme.
2. Complete the institution's admission and international-student process.
3. After admission, receive the Form I-20 and follow the school's instructions.
4. Pay the required SEVIS I-901 fee and complete the DS-160 visa application as applicable.
5. Schedule and attend the required visa appointment/interview, then review entry and status conditions before travel.

Common supporting documents

- Passport
- Form I-20 from the school
- DS-160 confirmation
- SEVIS I-901 fee evidence where applicable
- Visa application/appointment evidence
- Admission letter and academic records as appropriate
- Financial evidence showing ability to cover study/living costs where requested

United States: planning your study application

Admission and visa are separate decisions

A university offer does not by itself guarantee a visa. First confirm the exact programme admission conditions and deadline; then follow the current immigration route and evidence requirements for your nationality and circumstances.

Study planning checklist

- Check whether the programme is STEM-designated if STEM OPT is relevant to your planning.
- Compare tuition, scholarships, assistantships and estimated living expenses.
- Check each university's English and standardized-testing policy because requirements vary.

After arrival

- Present required documents at the port of entry.
- Follow the school's international-student check-in instructions.
- Maintain full-time enrollment and other F-1 status requirements.
- Use your DSO as the first institutional contact for immigration-status questions.

Before submitting your visa application

- Check passport validity and identity details.
- Use the latest official application form/process for your country of residence.
- Make sure names, dates and education history are consistent across documents.
- Keep copies of submitted forms, receipts, appointment confirmations and supporting evidence.
- Check whether documents need certified translation and whether originals must be presented.
- Review the exact visa conditions after grant before travelling.

Useful official links

- [Official visa guidance](https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/student-visa.html) — <https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/student-visa.html>
- [Official immigration/study information](https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/) — <https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/>

ViaSphere counsellor checklist

Use this page as a preparation worksheet. The exact evidence depends on the student, programme, nationality and current rules.

Area	Check	Status
Course	Programme, duration, level and campus confirmed	■
University	Official programme/admissions page reviewed	■
English test	Accepted test and minimum section/overall scores checked	■
Academic documents	Transcripts/certificates and translations checked	■
Funds	Current official financial evidence requirements checked	■
Passport	Validity and personal details checked	■
Accommodation	Plan/evidence prepared if required	■
Insurance/health	Current requirement checked	■
Visa application	Current official route and forms checked	■
Arrival	Registration/orientation/travel plan prepared	■

Official-source rule

If this guide conflicts with an official immigration authority, embassy/consulate, university or testing-provider page, follow the current official source. ViaSphere should not be treated as the issuing authority for any visa or admission decision.